

Editorial

How Broad Is Your Broadband?

THERE IS A joke going on around the country, and it is called broadband.

It has been a joke for quite some time now, but what grabs our attention is that companies selling 'broadband services' are actually going to town about how fast their speeds are, and how cheap their rates are. The lowest quoted rates "start at Rs 240."

The definition of Broadband, according to the new Broadband Policy of the Indian Government, is a service that is capable of "minimum download speeds of 256 Kbps."

Here is the real deal, the bitter truth. In almost all cases, home broadband in India has always meant speeds of 128 Kbps. And we are not even talking last mile here, as users of cable Internet have found to their chagrin for quite some time now.

So who are the so-called broadband service providers fooling? Well... you.

Call up any Internet service provider in India, and the well-trained, well-accented customer service representative would say that his company provides broadband services at speeds of 128 Kbps.

I asked a national-level service provider: "Will I always get speeds of 128 Kbps?"

Their reply: "No Sir, not always. But most times, definitely. It would depend on traffic on that particular day. It could range from 64 Kbps to 128 Kbps."

Next question: "Do you know that the government of India has specified that the minimum download speed at the last mile should be 256 Kbps for your service to even be called broadband?"

The reply: "Umm, maybe, Sir. But I am only going by what has been told to me, Sir." Click. Hang up.

In the US, 51.42 per cent of all home users of the Internet have broadband, while a mind-boggling 79.06 per cent of all office users have at least a T1 line to access the Internet. The corresponding figure for India? 0.02 per cent, according to the Department of Telecommunications.

The US figures were not created by magic, but because bandwidth has been freed up, and the government does not interfere with implementation.

Broadband is not a luxury. It is the fuel for growth, the seed that needs to be watered for a wide variety of personal and business applications. Lives can be saved



Sachin Kalbag Executive Editor

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when hospitals implement telemedicine over broadband; companies save lakhs in travel costs by implementing video-conferencing; international calls could be made cheaper, boosting business.

These applications are only the tip of the iceberg.

Service providers are making a mockery of broadband in this country, losing customer trust each day. When real broadband providers enter the home market, it will be scepticism that will greet them. It will not be a happy situation.

The joke going on around the country—called broadband—it's on us.

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